contained a commitment of the new government to pursue internal peace and regional development.

To implement the state's peace policy agenda with the EAGs, President Thein Sein assigned two peace teams, Team A and Team B, at the beginning of the peace process (Min Zaw Oo 2014). Team A was formed by powerful lawmakers from the ruling party, Aung Thaung and his close ally Thein Zaw (who was also a retired general and had a reputation as a moderate when dealing with Kachin ethnic groups under the previous government) (Aung Naing Oo 2014). According to internal sources, the initial slow reactions of the EAGs to the president's peace offer prompted the government to look for other alternatives that might produce dramatic changes in the ongoing peace discussions. Around that period, the president and his top executives began to re-engage the country with the international community, especially with Scandinavian countries, and individual policy advocates from non-governmental institutions, such as Myanmar Egress and the Vahu Development Institute.

By the end of 2011, on the president's verbal instruction, Union Minister Aung Min (then Minister for Railways) initiated peace discussions with some of the EAGs, taking assistance from Harn Yawnghwe, a powerful political exile and director of the Euro-Burma Office. Yawnghwe acted as a go-between for the government peace team and some ethnic armed groups with whom he had long-established personal networks. Consequently, Team B was formed at the end of 2011 with Aung Min as its leader. Soon after its formation, the team gained momentum. Several armed groups, including one of the largest armed groups, the Karen National Union (KNU), signed a ceasefire agreement with the government. Thereafter, Team A slowly became inactive after the first quarter of 2012.

With the initial success of Team B, the president began to groom it by granting a higher executive mandate to the leader and creating a technical team to support its work on the peace process. He created a "super cabinet", effectively promoting and transferring Aung Min to the president's office in August 2012 to oversee the running of the ministries, together with Industry Minister Soe Thein (another powerful minister in the cabinet) (Callahan 2012). Aung Min thereafter enjoyed the highest executive mandate, to be in charge of the government peace team and executive authority on supervising ministerial affairs related to foreign policy, security, peace, and the rule of law (personal note from senior staff of the President's Office, 2014). To institutionalize Minister Aung Min's